



Rural Radio Resource Pack

No 03/3

LIVESTOCK HEALTH

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Livestock health

TECHNICAL INFORMATION

(and suggestions for using RRRPs in the studio)

The value of healthy livestock

For farming families who are struggling to earn a living, livestock health may not be their greatest priority. Keeping their own family members fed and healthy will naturally be their first concern. However, it is widely recognised that rearing healthy livestock offers many poor families a way out of their poverty. Healthy livestock are productive livestock, not only providing food and income from their meat, milk and eggs, but also providing labour for farming and transport, and manure as a source of fertilizer and fuel. Livestock can also be a way for farmers to save and build their capital. Smaller animals such as sheep and goats are particularly valuable for poorer families, as individual animals can easily be sold when money is needed by the family.

Keeping livestock healthy

The real secret to keeping healthy livestock is not allowing animals to become sick in the first place; as with human health, prevention is much better than cure, not least because once one animal becomes sick or dies, there is a strong risk that the illness will spread to other animals in the herd or flock. Keeping animals healthy means ensuring a good, balanced diet, availability of clean water, and good, clean housing.

In addition to these three basics, farmers should also protect their livestock against diseases by having them vaccinated. Six months is usually the best age to have young animals such as cattle, vaccinated, but this can vary. If animals graze outside, farmers should also control their access to pasture, changing the area where animals graze every two or three months. This will help to reduce instances of tick-borne disease. Dipping cattle with acaricides will also kill ticks.

De-worming animals is another good way to keep them healthy. By killing the worms, farmers are letting their animals get the full benefit from the food that they eat. This makes the animals more productive, returning the benefits to the farmers.

Keeping healthy livestock obviously requires considerable investment of money, time and other resources. However, the income and other benefits that can be gained from healthy animals ought to make this investment worthwhile. In *Livestock need investment* a Chief Veterinary Officer working for the Zambian Ministry of Agriculture and Co-operatives talks about the benefits farmers can get from investing in their livestock, particularly investments made when the animals are young. He begins by urging farmers to allow new born calves to suckle from their mothers, so as to drink the valuable first milk, called colostrum, which contains antibodies the calf needs to fight infection during the first few months of its life.

The basic rules of livestock health are also emphasised by Dr David Ikiror, a Kenyan animal health scientist in the interview *Meeting health standards for export*. Dr Ikiror believes that exports of livestock and livestock products from Kenya could be an important factor in the country's economic recovery. However, attaining the high standards needed for exports will demand a more professional approach to livestock rearing than in the past.

One success story of livestock production comes in the interview *Cleanliness and diet*. This features a farmer in The Gambia who for the last 12 years has won the annual, national competition for the best ram. She and her husband explain the simple secrets of top quality livestock rearing.

The importance and the difficulty of vaccination programmes

Vaccination campaigns can be a very effective way of preventing the spread of many livestock diseases. However, if farmers fail to bring their livestock to be vaccinated, or only bring some of their animals, the benefits of the programme can be lost. Once an animal is vaccinated, it takes a few weeks for the animal to develop resistance. During this period it will still be vulnerable to the disease, and may be infected by other livestock. Hence for a vaccination campaign to be fully effective, a farmer must have all his or her animals vaccinated, and prevent them coming into contact with non-vaccinated animals for the required period.

In *Vaccination campaigns in remote areas* a representative of the Cameroon ministry responsible for livestock explains the importance of vaccination campaigns and the difficulties of organising effective campaigns for dispersed communities of livestock farmers.

Regulation of veterinary drug sales

Many farmers, particularly those who are illiterate, are in a weak position when they try to buy medicines for their animals. Unscrupulous traders may cheat farmers by selling them adulterated or unsuitable products, or else they may be given poor advice if those selling drugs have little knowledge of animal health. How can those who sell drugs be better regulated so that farmers get the help they need? In Nigeria the government recently authorised the National Agency for Food Drug Administration and Control (NAFDAC) to regulate those who sell veterinary drugs, in order to try to improve the situation for livestock farmers. *Controlling fake veterinary drugs* reports on the problems caused by fake drugs in Nigeria, and the efforts of NAFDAC to control them.

Training community animal health workers

To become a fully qualified veterinary officer usually takes several years of training, and requires considerable financial investment. Not surprisingly, the number of qualified vets in Africa is insufficient to meet the needs of the millions of livestock keepers. In response to this situation, some governments and also non-government organisations have started to train community members in basic animal health care. In Malawi this is being done under a government scheme, the Basic Animal Health

Services Project, whereby farmer groups select ‘farmer technicians’ for training, and are provided with a box of drugs which the technician can use to treat group members’ animals. In this case the farmer technicians are only taught very simple techniques, such as giving drugs by mouth, and not more complex techniques such as injecting animals. The interview *Drug boxes for farmer groups* gives more information about this project.

In Tanzania, the NGO FARM-Africa has trained community animal health workers to a higher level of skill. They are given four weeks’ training, and are equipped with a ‘starter kit’ which includes drugs, needles and syringes. These trainees expect to be able to earn an income from their work. However the drop out rate for trainees can be high, especially if they are unable to get enough work, or are not sufficiently paid for their services. Some also criticise the quality of service the trainees can give. The interview *Barefoot vets - a stop-gap measure* explores the advantages and problems of community based animal health workers.

Disease diagnosis systems

The spread of contagious livestock diseases is a major threat to both domestic production and livestock trade. Stopping an outbreak of disease from spreading demands very quick action to control animal movements. Hence effective systems to diagnose diseases when outbreaks occur are essential. However, such systems require resources such as vehicles, refrigerated containers, laboratory facilities and trained staff, resources that are in short supply in many countries. In *Learning to diagnose disease*, a private veterinarian working in northern Zimbabwe describes outreach work he has done with farmers to train them to recognise disease symptoms. Such farmer-based diagnosis can never be a fully effective substitute for a test-based system, but may help to reduce the spread of disease when laboratory services are too distant to be effective.

Using this RRRP in the studio

As with human health, livestock health is a subject that must be handled carefully. Broadcasting poor information is worse than broadcasting no information at all. The interviews in this pack do not address how to diagnose and treat particular diseases; the information is more general. If you feel you want to give livestock farmers specific disease-related advice, you may wish to invite suitable experts into the studio, or record further interviews in the field. These can then complement the general information available here, with advice relevant to the specific disease and health issues present in your country.

Issues that you could tackle using this pack are:

How can farmers keep their livestock healthy?

Preventative health care is the most important aspect of livestock health. *Livestock need investment*, *Meeting health standards for export* and *Cleanliness and diet* all cover the basic rules of keeping livestock healthy; these are essentially providing good feed, clean water, and clean and appropriate housing. Vaccination, dipping against ticks and using anti-worm treatments regularly are also important. While this information is covered by the three interviews, you might also want to discuss the requirements of particular types of animals, including poultry. For this you will need to provide the information yourself or invite an outside speaker, such as a veterinary officer.

How can vaccination services be provided to remote areas?

In Cameroon, the veterinary health services have found some farmers reluctant to bring their animals for vaccination. One reason for this is the cost of the injections. You could discuss the importance of vaccination - both for the individual farmer, and in terms of national livestock production. How effective are vaccination services in your country? Do farmers have to pay? How are farmers made aware of the importance of having their animals vaccinated? You could use *Vaccination campaigns in remote areas* to raise these issues, and perhaps invite a representative of the government vaccination services to comment on the approach being taken in your country.

How to increase the numbers of trained veterinary staff working in rural areas?

It is likely that the number of veterinary staff working in the rural areas in your country is too low to meet the need of livestock farmers. What are the possible solutions to this problem? You might want to invite a representative of the ministry responsible for livestock to comment on the current policy. *Drug boxes for farmer groups* deals with a government initiative in Malawi to train and equip farmer groups in basic animal health care. *Barefoot vets - a stop-gap measure* looks at the training of community animal health workers by a non government organisation in Tanzania. You may wish to invite either a farmer or a barefoot vet to discuss the benefits and potential problems of such schemes.

How should veterinary drugs be regulated to prevent fake or useless drugs being sold?

There are various issues involved in controlling the sale of veterinary drugs. One problem is of fake drugs, adulterated drugs or out-of-date drugs being sold by dishonest traders. You might want to explore how farmers can protect themselves against such people. There may also be a problem of those selling drugs not being sufficiently expert to choose the correct drugs for farmers to buy. This raises the issue of how those selling drugs should be regulated. If you wish to compare the situation in your country with that in another, *Controlling fake veterinary drugs* deals with the issue of regulation in Nigeria.

The importance of disease diagnosis systems and farmer knowledge

If there have been instances of infectious disease outbreaks in your country in recent months, your listeners may be interested to learn about the systems for disease monitoring that are operating. These systems may be under pressure as they require considerable resources to be effective. You might want to explore the challenges facing these services and how they are trying to overcome them. *Learning to diagnose disease* raises the issue of whether farmers can be usefully involved in disease diagnosis, and the difficulties facing diagnosis systems in Zimbabwe. You could use the interview as a starting point for a discussion on how livestock farmers can receive extension and training in animal health care. One idea being tried in Kenya, for example, is Livestock Farmer Field Schools, where groups of farmers are trained in livestock management.

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Livestock health

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<i>Livestock need investment</i> A Chief Veterinary Officer at the Zambian Ministry of Agriculture talks about the importance of preventative health care, and the value of investing in the health of young animals.	4'16"
<i>Vaccination campaigns in remote areas</i> A divisional delegate for the Cameroon ministry responsible for livestock discusses the importance and difficulties of vaccination campaigns in remote areas.	3'59"
<i>Controlling fake veterinary drugs</i> A senior veterinary research officer describes the need for regulation in the sales of veterinary drugs, to prevent sales of fake, out-of-date or adulterated drugs, and a recent initiative being undertaken in Nigeria to achieve this.	4'00"
<i>Meeting health standards for export</i> Dr David Ikiror, an animal health scientist working in Kenya describes the basic principles of good livestock health and argues that livestock farmers must become more market oriented.	4'05"
<i>Cleanliness and diet</i> The Gambia's champion sheep and ram breeders explain the secrets of how they have won the best ram competition at the annual Tobaski festival for the last twelve years.	2'51"
<i>Barefoot vets - a stop-gap measure</i> Dr Sultan of FARM-Africa Tanzania discusses a project to train community animal health workers, describing the training system, the benefits the barefoot vets are offering to communities and their relationship with government veterinary services.	3'46"
<i>Drug boxes for farmer groups</i> A senior animal health advisor from Malawi describes a government programme to train and equip 'farmer technicians' to perform basic animal health care.	4'19"
<i>Learning to diagnose disease</i> Dr Donald Sibanda, a private vet working in northern Zimbabwe, describes the training he gives to farmers so that they can recognise common illness types, and discusses the difficulties facing disease diagnosis systems in the country.	3'32"

Livestock health

Livestock need investment

Cue:

Rearing livestock for meat and milk production, or for sale, is often recommended as a way for poor families to escape from poverty. This may be true, but profitable livestock production is not free of cost. In fact, if livestock are to be healthy and productive they need investment, investment of time, resources and money.

Dominic Minyoi is a Chief Veterinary Officer working for the Zambian Ministry of Agriculture and Co-operatives. He recently spoke to Chris Kakunta about the importance of investment, and why the first priority for livestock farmers is to invest in the health of their new born animals, such as calves and lambs. Allowing a new born animal to feed on its mother's milk is an extremely important first investment, as it helps to protect the animal against prevailing diseases.

IN: "Once a calf is born ...

OUT: ...too late for anybody to intervene."

DUR'N 4'16""

BACK ANNOUNCEMENT:

Dominic Minyoi with advice for livestock keepers on the importance of investing in their animals.

Transcript

Minyoi

Once a calf is born it must be exposed to colostrum. Colostrum is the first milk that comes from the mother. Within 24 hours of birth that calf should be made to suckle with that one. It gives it all the protection because colostrum carries all the necessary antibodies to protect the calf against the prevailing diseases that are in that area. And also apart from that, most farmers you find they don't really let the calf suckle. So from birth the calf should be let to suckle until they are satisfied, that's when the farmers can get the milk. We do know that they rely on this milk as well but the calf needs it more for growth. And as the calf grows up they must at least organise the pasture, even from crop residues. They can put those in the kraal, whatever stover, maize stover that is left, whatever from the groundnuts and beans that can be fed to the animals during the dry season when the feed is inadequate. And it is important at this point in time that they must deworm at least twice per year. This is before the rains and after the rains so that when the rains have come in and the grass is mushrooming, the calves have got access to grass; they can put on weight because they won't have a worm burden. Vaccination is very very important in certain age groups. They can do that for anthrax, they can do that for all the other preventable diseases.

Kakunta

Your emphasis has been on the calf. Are you saying when you look after a calf properly, you are guaranteeing that the future animals will be healthy?

- Minyoi** Definitely, once you start looking after a calf very well that calf will grow into a strong adult. And that strong adult can only be strong if it is also exposed to certain interventions like vaccinations, de-worming, good housing, provision of water, all those are things that should be made available to the animals. In the village set up they can even use troughs, these dug-out canoes; put water in there. The animals will have access to water whenever they feel like drinking water. Not where as of now, they graze somewhere else, they are taken for water somewhere else, and by the time they come back to the kraal they are really thirsty. So we should make these things available to the livestock for them to be able to live within the surroundings instead of venturing out where they might contract a disease through mixing with other cattle.
- Kakunta** *There are certain situations here in Zambia, Dr Minyoi, for instance in the southern part of the country, where we have East Coast Fever, commonly known as Corridor Disease. We are finding that the small-scale farmers' animals are dying, while in the same area the commercial farmers' animals are still healthy. What practical lessons have you learned from such a scenario?*
- Minyoi** What it is, is that to prevent tick-borne diseases, one must dip the animals. And communal dip tanks are there, they exist, but these people are not co-operating, to be able to come together so that they can have their animals dipped. People should be able to invest a bit in livestock, so that they can buy the dip chemicals. And they can approach our officers, our officers can assist them in prescribing what kind of chemicals to buy. They should be doing that twice a month in the rainy season, and once every month in the dry season. Because if they dip regularly, then Corridor Disease will be something that they will hear about but not really their concern.
- Kakunta** *But why do you think the farmers are so reluctant in terms of preventative measures? Does it mean there is a problem somewhere in terms of attitudes?*
- Minyoi** I can attribute this partly to poor extension services. If the extension was good, farmers would have been taught how to look after animals, and then everybody would be taken on board. But what it is now, is that sometimes our extension is failing to reach the people. But where it is reaching some people don't want to spend, they won't invest in livestock. Livestock is a business just like any other business, they have to invest. And above all, they should attend to their regular requirements in as far as their health is concerned. Because these animals are just left to herdsmen, and when herdsmen come there is no request for a report. They should also keep their records so that these herdsmen are held accountable. Because what is happening, farmers don't even know how the animals are, they are just told 'The animal is dead.' And you can not run a business like that. They must be part and parcel of that livestock-rearing group. They must be able to monitor

the animals and see how they are getting on, so that they can report on time. Reporting condition on time, or reporting a situation on time gets one better results than reporting late, because when you report late it may be too late for anybody to intervene. *End of track.*

Livestock health

Vaccination campaigns in remote areas

Cue:

Contagious or infectious livestock diseases are one of the biggest threats to livestock production in many parts of Africa. Controlling the spread of infectious diseases is usually the task of the government veterinary services, and one of the most effective ways of achieving this is through vaccination campaigns. But organising vaccination campaigns in remote areas is not easy. Many farmers are unaware of the benefits vaccination can give, and may also fear, sometimes correctly, that they will have to pay for any vaccines their animals are given. These factors can make them reluctant to bring all their animals for vaccination, which can greatly reduce the effectiveness of the campaign.

How to improve this situation? One important factor is good communication with remote communities, as Martha Chindong found out when she spoke to Mrs Ndeng Ambe Bibiana, Divisional delegate for the Ministry of Livestock, Fisheries and Animal Industries in Cameroon's Ngoketunjia division. She asked Mrs Ndeng how her department was able to organise effective vaccination campaigns for dispersed pastoral communities.

IN: "In fact that is one of the greatest ...
OUT: ...will be for their own good."
DUR'N 3'59"

BACK ANNOUNCEMENT:

Mrs Ndeng Ambe Bibiana encouraging livestock farmers to take advantage of vaccination programmes and protect their animals against costly infectious diseases.

Transcript

Ndeng In fact that is one of the greatest problems we face. Before we go in for an exercise like this we call for sensitisation meetings. We have to actually educate them. We call for meetings here and there at the level of the division, at the level of the sub-division, at the level of the centres. So we work a lot before we start the exercise. If you just take off that you are going to do vaccination you will fail woefully because really people are not educated. So we have to sensitise them a lot. You go out to sensitise them, you call meetings to sensitise them and when they are fully prepared and aware that's when you go out. And in fact you have to work within the season.

Chindong *How do you carry out the vaccination proper?*

Ndeng This we do by organising them according to their locality. So that those graziers in that locality can bring the animals there to avoid long trekking so that the animals are not tired when they arrive there.

- Chindong** *Some farmers, they feel scared when you say they should bring their cattle for vaccination maybe because they fear you will tax them. Do you face such problems?*
- Ndeng** A lot. In the past this vaccination used to be free. Government used to provide a vaccine and we did the work free of charge for them. So they started when things were not moving well, we started charging them 20 francs per dose until we are now at 130. So they feel that the money is too much. But at least what we have experienced this year is that the number of cattle coming up is increasing because last year the vaccine was 150 francs per dose but this year it has dropped to 130 and I think the graziers are a bit happier. They still want a drop but you see the vaccines themselves cost a lot.
- Chindong** *Now have you made this problem known to the ministry, that the vaccines are too expensive for poor farmers and isolated farmers?*
- Ndeng** Of course, when we receive their complaints - that is why we are there - when we receive their complaints we send them to the higher quarters. At meetings we complain. In writing we complain. They know we are complaining. And the result of their complaining now you can see last year as I say it was 150 francs per dose but this year it is 130 francs per dose. So they are happy that at least their complaints are being looked into.
- Chindong** *If you were to pass on a message to the farmers what will you tell them?*
- Ndeng** I will tell them to continue to have courage and know that we are out for the protection of their animals and not really for these revenue collections because if we were really out to collect money for these vaccines and their services, they cannot pay for those services and the cost of the vaccines. So we are really doing it to see to it that we have meat in the market and to do this we must protect the health of the animals. If we don't protect the health of the animals we will not have good meat in the market and even the quantity we need.
- Chindong** *Before we go I don't know whether you have any last word for the farmers?*
- Ndeng** Yes in fact I would like to advise the farmers that when there is an exercise of this nature they should present all their animals for vaccination because it is needless leaving some behind. Because when you leave some behind, those that you didn't vaccinate will contaminate those that you vaccinated and therefore the money you even spend vaccinating the few was useless. So it was unnecessary for you to bring the few. And if you don't bring, your animals will contaminate neighbouring animals, which is not good. We are there to see that they grow healthy animals. When your animals are healthy you

sell them at a higher cost. So in fact if they can bring out all animals for vaccination, it will be for their own good. *End of track.*

Livestock health

Controlling fake veterinary drugs

Cue:

While livestock farmers should make every effort to stop their animals becoming sick, some illness is inevitable. In such cases, the only cure may be a drug that the farmer will have to buy. Sometimes however, the veterinary drugs that are available for sale may do more harm than good. In Nigeria for example, many of the drugs that are sold are fake, or else are too old and are no longer effective. Such drugs cost farmers large amounts of money, but do nothing for their livestock.

To address this problem, the Nigerian government recently authorised the National Agency for Food Drug Administration and Control, known as NAFDAC, to regulate those who sell veterinary drugs, something which has not been done in the past. Tunde Fatunde spoke to Dr Jerry Abenga, a senior veterinary research officer from Kaduna State, about the problems of controlling the supply of veterinary drugs in the country, and the progress made by NAFDAC. He began by asking Dr Abenga to explain the problem of unregulated veterinary drugs in Nigeria.

IN: “Because there is no regulation...”

OUT: ...so that these drugs are identified.”

DUR’N 4’00”

BACK ANNOUNCEMENT:

Dr Jerry Abenga emphasising the need for collaboration in the battle against fake veterinary drugs in Nigeria.

Transcript

Abenga Because there is no regulation on who sells veterinary drugs, there has been a lot of importation of drugs that have been found to be fake.

Fatunde *For example?*

Abenga There are several antibiotics, particularly the tetracyclines, that many of them don’t have the necessary chemicals to cure diseases. And also a lot of drugs meant for the control of ecto-parasites, many of them have no effect on animals.

Fatunde *What do you mean by ‘ecto-parasites’?*

Abenga Ticks, flies and other parasites that infest the body of animals.

Fatunde *Now these drugs are they adulterated or are they expired or is it that they are not adapted to the specific species of animals we have in Nigeria?*

Abenga Many of the drugs because they are not properly regulated, many of them are expired, some because of the keeping quality. We are in a tropical environment and some of these drugs are exposed to the heat

of the sun and as a result there is degeneration. And these drugs, many of them they don't have effect to cure disease anymore.

Fatunde *What are the peculiar problems being faced by farmers when they buy these drugs and the animals that have been affected?*

Abenga Some of these drugs are toxic, some cause decay at the point of injection, some even cause abortion. Also these drugs because they don't cure, the animal dies of infection. So you find out that the farmer spends so much money buying the drug and the animal still dies. So he lost his money in buying of drugs and his animals also die.

Fatunde *How do they know that these drugs are adulterated? What are the processes?*

Abenga When a vet buys a drug and treats an animal and the animal does not improve then it's a clear sign that the drug is probably not containing the necessary chemicals to cure the infection. And when that is established, further confirmation is done in the laboratory. And there are some companies doing chemical analysis of these drugs. And because of this some drugs have been found not to contain, sometimes even nothing that could cure disease.

Fatunde *How is the government tackling these problems?*

Abenga For many years this area has been neglected by the government. But looking at the affect of animal disease on our economy, the federal government through the agency of NAFDAC, that is National Agency for Food Drug Administration and Control, they have now stepped in to look at the shelves of shop owners that sell veterinary drugs, who want to look for their license and to analyse these drugs, to make sure that even veterinary drugs come under their control.

Fatunde *What is your own assessment so far on the work being done by NAFDAC?*

Abenga Well NAFDAC has just stepped in to control veterinary drugs and we are still waiting to see the impact of their activity. As of now fake veterinary drugs are still being sold in several parts of the country.

Fatunde *Is there going to be a collaborative work between NAFDAC, farmers and veterinary institutes in Nigeria with a view to tackling this problem?*

Abenga Yes NAFDAC cannot succeed in the war against fake veterinary drugs alone. There needs to be collaboration with the other research institutes like Nigerian Veterinary Research Institute and several universities who have faculties of veterinary medicine so that these drugs are identified. *End of track.*

Livestock Health

Meeting health standards for export

Cue:

Kenya is a country well-known for its livestock keeping. Recently however, some have argued that the nature of livestock keeping in Kenya needs to change, in order to increase the economic benefit to the country. Central to this idea is the need to export more animals and animal products to foreign markets, where Kenyan exports can earn good prices. But if a country is serious about selling livestock to foreign markets, achieving the highest standards of animal health is critically important. Where health standards are low, outbreaks of infectious diseases such as Foot and Mouth disease can easily occur, leading to bans on all animal movements and the closing of borders to livestock trade.

But how can costly disease outbreaks be stopped? To find out, Eric Kadenge spoke to Dr David Ikiror, an animal health scientist working in Kenya.

IN: "Just like human beings...
OUT: ... reap the maximum benefits."
DUR'N: 4'05"

BACK ANNOUNCEMENT:

Dr David Ikiror, emphasising how good livestock health can bring substantial economic benefits.

Transcript

Ikiror Just like human beings, we need to be healthy in order to be productive. So for you to be able to get the optimal production and productivity from your livestock, surely you have to keep your livestock healthy otherwise the feeding and the other things that you do alone will not be enough. And also of course, if you keep your livestock healthy, then also you can access markets.

Kadenge *Now that is very very interesting and I would like to go ahead and find out - what are some of the ways that we can prevent our animals from getting sick?*

Ikiror We all know that proper feeding is very very important in maintaining human health. The same thing applies to animals. They need to get a balanced diet: proteins, they need to get vitamins, they need to get energy, they need to get water, mineral salts, they are all very necessary to keep our animals healthy. Also we need to, just like for human beings, we need to talk of hygiene. We need to have a clean environment where our animals stay. In other words, if an animal is kept like in a zero grazing unit, you need to be cleaning the place - removing the dung, removing the urine - to make sure that the environment is clean. And of course even the housing is important especially for young animals. They should be housed in such a way that you protect them from excesses of weather, like excessive wind,

which can predispose them to pneumonia or also rainfall. We need to make sure that our animals are protected from pests. We are talking of things like ticks, so we need to dip our animals regularly. We need to make sure that our animals also are de-wormed; de-worm them regularly to lower the worm burden. We need to make sure that also our animals are vaccinated against some - there are some diseases which can be protected through vaccination. So those are some of the ways in which we can keep our animals healthy.

Kadenge *And for the sake of maybe a farmer or a livestock trader as you said - that would like to be able to maybe identify when his livestock has a disease, are there some common things that one can probably notice that will indicate that an animal is unhealthy?*

Ikiror We can talk of somebody knowing the signs of a healthy animal. A healthy animal will usually show a smooth hair coat, smooth skin, it will be active and the eyes will not be tearing. If it is an animal with a tail - the tail will be moving continuously, it will be walking normally. If the urine is passed, it will be normal urine. The dung also it will be normal - normal colour, normal consistency. Then if it is an animal that's for example producing milk - if it is a cow or a goat which is milking then the milk will be normal, of normal colour and consistency. And also if you look at this animal on the body, you will not see any sign of parasites for example. That is a sign of an animal that is healthy. So in other words, the normal things that you would expect a normal animal to have.

Kadenge *Is there anything else that you would like to add?*

Ikiror What I would like to add is to say that basically, livestock is now being identified as one of the important engines that will spur economic development. In fact if we talk about the recovery of the economy, livestock is being earmarked as one of the main drivers. And it is being seen not only producing food for our consumption but we are also thinking in terms of producing these animal products and also animals themselves for the export markets. And as a farmer it will be very very necessary for us to double our efforts and even improving our livestock and also its important not only to look at the health but let's look at the kind of breeds that we keep in our area. That's why I am saying that it is important that we seek advice from experts so that we can get advice on which animals to keep in which particular area and on the general management. The important thing is we should move away from subsistence form of livestock production to more market oriented. That way as farmers and as a nation we can reap the maximum benefits. *End of track.*

Livestock health

Cleanliness and diet

Cue:

For sheep breeders in The Gambia, the Muslim feast of Tobaski is one of the highlights of the year. During the feast rams are sacrificed, and prizes are awarded for the best animals. Breeding top quality sheep and rams requires a lot of work and attention to detail. Maintaining good hygiene standards and feeding a balanced diet are particularly important. To find out more, Ismaila Senghore decided to speak to the winners of this year's best ram competition, Mr and Mrs Jeng, at their farm near Banjul. In fact the Jeng's animal husbandry is so good that they have won the competition for the last 12 years. Mrs Jeng began by explaining the importance of cleaning the shed where the sheep and rams eat and sleep.

IN: "Everyday we clean it ...

OUT: ...taking care of them."

DUR'N 2'51"

BACK ANNOUNCEMENT:

Ismaila Senghore speaking to Mr. And Mrs Jeng, winners of this year's Tobaski ram competition in The Gambia.

Transcript

Mrs Jeng Everyday we clean it, clean where they sleep, cleaning as much as possible and looking after them you see. They eat a lot that is why we have three to four different kinds of varieties of food so that they can mix the foods everyday, mix up, rather than everyday eating the groundnut hay here or everyday eating the corn or everyday eating maize. And also we give them clean water, clean water, everyday we have to change the water, clean water. And everyday we have to broom this area to make it clean. We don't have to leave them the dirty water.

Senghore *Ok and I can see that you have a very good shed because the roofing is so comfortable for the animals?*

Mrs Jeng Yes because rain should not be pouring on them everyday, leaving them outside on the streets roaming about eating any different kind of food they see, no. You see they will not be healthy over there because when they eat the rice that have oil, they have diarrhoea. We choose the kind of food we have to give them. Even the grass, we have to cut the grass. Nice grasses we sow, they cut them, bring them here to feed them rather than leaving them on the streets roaming about...

Senghore *Scavenging for food. Can you tell me how you recognise sickness in your animals if you sense they are sick? How do you know?*

Mrs Jeng Yes if sometimes you see one sheep lying on the ground for about one, two hours, three hours, you see them sometimes they get diarrhoea, you come and help them. That is why we employ this boy for the

helping, 24 hours. Even at night we look at them. If we hear that some of them had gone out of their room we have to go after them and tie them. If they are sick sometimes they get diarrhoea, we have to go to the pharmacy and get some, we have to get the doctors. First advice from the veterinary, we know them very well. Even for one hour if you see them get diarrhoea you have to take them otherwise it will weaken them.

Senghore *Now what kind of health intervention do the veterinary people help you with?*

Mrs Jeng The veterinary people they help us with the vaccinations which we buy from them.

Senghore *In other words you feed your sheep well, give them adequate water to drink and you heed to veterinary advice at all times?*

Mrs Jeng Of course we take great care of them.

Senghore *Thank you very much Mrs Rohie Jeng it has been a pleasure talking to you.*

Mrs Jeng Yes thank you very much. Also you can have one minute with my husband because he's also the best farmer here.

Senghore *Ok then let me just walk over to Mr Jeng. Mr Jeng now how would you summarise your activities here?*

Mr Jeng Well just keep on trying, just watch them closely and keep them clean, keep them happy, keep them eating all the time. If anybody does that you have the same thing, there is no secret, only to be taking care of them. *End of track.*

Livestock health

Barefoot vets - a stop-gap measure

Cue:

In dealing with the challenge of poor veterinary facilities and low staff numbers, training local people as community animal health workers, or barefoot vets, has plenty of advantages. The training may only take a few weeks, and because the barefoot vets are already living in rural areas, it is much easier for them to serve dispersed farming communities. But training schemes of this kind are not always popular with agricultural ministries, particularly if the barefoot vets do not fall under their regulation. There have also been doubts about the professionalism of some trainees, who may prescribe drugs or treatments that are not needed in order to increase their earnings. To learn more about the benefits and problems associated with community animal health workers, Lazarus Laiser visited FARM-Africa, an organisation which has been training barefoot vets in Tanzania. He spoke to Dr Sultan, who began by describing the training process.

IN: "Actually it takes four weeks ...
OUT: ...government will give them support"
DUR'N 3'46"

BACK ANNOUNCEMENT:

Dr Sultan of FARM-Africa Tanzania urging the government to support the training of community animal health workers.

Transcript

Sultan Actually it takes four weeks and the training entails practical and theory. And after completion of the training we also give them a starter kit and this starter kit is free. And the starter kit is comprising of castrator, knapsack sprayer, hoof trimmer, syringes, needles and some drugs. This is a package, and we said that if we give this starter kit then they can regenerate income because the community based animal health workers are working, charging the services that they are offering to the community. So they will get the money, and with the money that they get they will replenish the drugs and also maybe buy other equipment if they are broken.

Laiser *Are the farmers now getting good services from their barefoot vet?*

Sultan Yes the farmers actually now are getting good service bearing in mind that these community based animal health workers are very close to the household. So it means to say that they no longer bother now to go to look for a village extension officer who maybe is residing about 10 – 15 kilometres away from where he is. So at least they have assisted them tremendously because they are very close now to the households, closer to the animals.

Laiser *If you compare the number of animals that were dying before these animal health officers, what can you say about this?*

Sultan They have assisted tremendously to reduce the death, that is mortality and also to reduce the illness. Because if you compare soon after the government had withdrawn from provision of animal health care because there was a gap of about 5-10 years that there was no animal health providers in some villages. So it means that many villagers they just turned to become health providers and they caused a lot of illness or they caused a lot of death to animals because they were not trained actually to offer such services.

Laiser *What can you say to the government of Tanzania regarding these animal health officers in the villages?*

Sultan Tanzania is third in Africa for having a large number of livestock, we have 17 million. And this 17 million head of cattle are found in the villages. So those who are suffering actually are the villagers. And these community based animal health workers are not dangerous, they are not going to hamper the system. The only thing is, they are assisting. They are actually a stop-gap measure. And we believe that maybe in 10-15 years to come when the government is in a good position to train these village extension officers and diploma holders, these people will eventually be replaced by those who are coming. But for the time being there is no way, we have at least to assist them. And since they are working hand in hand with the village government officers, I don't think there is any problem regarding the misuse of drugs or going against the ethics, because they actually don't do things which the village extension officer can do. For example they don't do operation, they don't attend major cases, they only do these primary health cases. And the one issue which maybe I would also like to air out is, the village government is empowered to withdraw all the kits and drugs from the trained community based animal health workers if the performance is dropping down, maybe because of laziness and what have you. So I hope and I believe that the government will give them support. *End of track.*

Livestock health

Drug boxes for farmer groups

Cue:

For livestock farmers, having access to good veterinary health care is extremely important. Obtaining the right drugs and treatment in good time can not only save the life of an individual animal, but may also stop a disease spreading through an entire herd or flock. Unfortunately, many countries do not have enough trained veterinary officers, particularly to serve remote rural communities. What can be done to address this problem?

One solution being tried in Malawi, is to train farmers in basic animal health care. These farmer technicians are able to supplement the work already being done by veterinary officers and their assistants. Part of the programme has also involved supplying drug boxes to farmer groups, which the farmer technicians are taught how to use. But how effective is this programme? Can trained farmers really offer good veterinary health care to their farmer groups and communities? To find out more, Excello Zidana spoke to Richard Mgombezulu, a senior veterinary development officer involved in the programme. He began by asking how the drug boxes are being managed.

IN: "These drug boxes are in two ...
OUT: ...reduce instances of diseases."
DUR'N 4'19"

BACK ANNOUNCEMENT:

Richard Mgombezulu with some advice for farmers on keeping their livestock disease-free.

Transcript

Mgombezulu These drug boxes are in two categories. Some of the drug boxes belong to the Assistant Veterinary Officers. The second category are drug boxes owned by farmer groups themselves. This was the initiative of the Basic Animal Health Services Project whereby we have farmer technicians who we call the 'key men', manning these drug boxes, though some of the boxes still are being manned by the veterinary assistants but those are very few.

Zidana *It takes the government two years to train veterinary officers to be handling drugs and the issues pertaining to administering of those drugs. How do you make sure that these farmers who manage the drugs are able to do the same job?*

Mgombezulu Well there are some drugs that farmers can administer and still some of the drugs have to be always administered by the Assistant Veterinary Officers. More especially the injectable drugs, it is a must that they are administered by the Assistant Veterinary Officers. But simple health care is what is being taken care of by the farmer technicians or the key men. For example, administration of vaccine against Newcastle

Disease, even the farmers themselves do administer the vaccine without a problem. But where injectable vaccine is concerned it is the responsibility of the Assistant Veterinary Officer. Some of the drugs that farmer technicians and key men are also able to administer comfortably are the de-wormers, especially those that are administered as a drench not as injectables.

Zidana *What mechanism is there to make sure that the drugs which are being sold by these key men, the drugs are not expired, things of that nature?*

Mgomezulu We encourage these farmer groups as much as possible to get the drugs that are far from the expiry date. But also we advise them that once they know that they have some drugs that are nearing expiry date they have to dispose of them.

Zidana *According to your evaluation are these drug boxes effective?*

Mgomezulu Yes I should say that these drug boxes are very effective, in the sense that we have seen the results. Disease instances have been reduced and we have even seen that livestock numbers, especially the goats as well as the chickens, the numbers are increasing.

Zidana *Now lastly how do you make sure that the livestock in the country are protected? I'm looking at the outbreaks like maybe Newcastle?*

Mgomezulu To ensure that we don't have serious outbreaks of Newcastle Disease we advise farmers to follow the right vaccination schedules. In Malawi we have been using La Sota vaccine mostly and therefore we recommend that they vaccinate the chickens four times in a year. That is vaccinating after each and every three months.

Zidana *Not when they have seen that there is an outbreak of Newcastle around?*

Mgomezulu No, because the vaccine does not work in a chicken that has already Newcastle Disease. But also what I would advise them is to adopt improved husbandry practices. They have to adopt good feeding practices, good housing practices, preventive measures such as de-worming, those are very very important in order to reduce instances of diseases. *End of track.*

Livestock health

Learning to diagnose disease

Cue:

Most experienced livestock farmers are able to judge when their animals are sick, but knowing exactly which disease an animal is suffering from is more difficult. For example, is it a tick-borne disease or an infectious virus? If a farmer does not know the answer, the animal is unlikely to get the correct treatment, and it may die. Diagnosing what disease an animal has is usually the job of trained veterinary officers. In some cases they will need to send samples from the animal to laboratories for testing. However, these disease diagnosis services are under huge pressure in much of Africa, and are often unable to help farmers living in remote areas.

Donald Sibanda is a private vet working in Matabeleland North province in Zimbabwe. He is very concerned about the problem of disease diagnosis facing farming communities, and believes one answer is to train farmers in recognising common disease symptoms. For the last few years he has been giving outreach training to farmers in the province. In this report he speaks to Busani Bafana about the challenges he has faced doing this outreach work, and the problems associated with disease diagnosis in Zimbabwe.

IN: "One of the problems ...
OUT: ...it's actually helping us."
DUR'N 3'32"

BACK ANNOUNCEMENT:

Dr Donald Sibanda describing the training he has given to farmers in recognising livestock disease symptoms.

Transcript

Sibanda One of the problems is also literacy because if you get maybe vets who cannot communicate with the local areas there is a language gap. But we have to talk in our local languages; if we get vets who talk in local languages and then have educational tours in the whole district from one area to another. I've done outreaches myself. We spend nearly the whole day doing lessons about common diseases. And after that I've seen a good improvement from that policy.

Bafana *In your operation you serve more than 300 communal farmers. What would you say can be done to identify diseases and ensure that they are treated quickly before they become a national disaster?*

Sibanda What I have done to the communal farmers which I've visited myself, I've had to teach people the common symptoms which animals show. I have taught those guys the common symptoms and then say, as soon as you see these you just call a veterinary extension officer. If they see that maybe the disease, they can't handle it, that's why they call me, that's why I have to visit them and so on. And if you had a call, they didn't understand before then you say that I have again to teach them

what are the symptoms or what they should do soon after that. And it has really helped.

Bafana *What systems exist in Zimbabwe for disease diagnosis and control? Do you think these are effective?*

Sibanda The systems that exist in Zimbabwe at the moment for disease diagnosis they are actually not effective because the veterinary department now is relying mostly on farmers. But farmers sometimes they don't know, they think of other reasons, some even think of witchcraft and so on which is actually wrong. We should have veterinary people in the field where those if they diagnose the disease then we have labs in Harare, for Foot and Mouth actually in South Africa. The problem that we have now is vehicles because some samples we have to rush them, we have to reach within 24 hours in a refrigerated container. And if you are deep in Matabeleland North you don't have vehicles just to travel, to reach Harare takes about 3 days which makes that disease diagnosis actually not effective.

Bafana *What practical advice, doctor, would you offer to farmers who have no access to lab facilities on recognising and where possible on controlling disease outbreaks?*

Sibanda Now we have just, there are some diseases which we have grouped on certain symptoms. We should just check that the animal is anaemic, you need to check the gums and then you see they are pale. Then there we just say if you see these diseases, these are tick-borne diseases, if you see this disease then maybe it is a viral disease. With that then we would treat; the treatment for tick-borne diseases as you know there are 2 or 3 drugs which we use. So it's better just to treat an animal with all the drugs so that we would fight many many diseases and conditions and so on. And if it is a viral then we avoid movement, letting that animal being stressed and so on, leave that animal at home. So with the teaching that is going on it's actually helping us. *End of track.*